

The Fox and the Grapes

On a warm afternoon, a fox wandered along a country lane looking for something to eat. He had searched beneath hedges and around fallen logs without much luck. At last he came to a vineyard surrounded by a low stone wall. Beyond it hung bunches of grapes, dark and shining in the sunlight. They looked cool, sweet, and exactly what he wanted after the dusty walk.

The fox found a gap in the wall and slipped inside. He stood beneath the nearest vine, measured the distance with his eyes, and sprang upward. His paws caught only air. He tried again from a small rock, then from a running start. Each leap brought him close enough to smell the fruit, but never close enough to bite it. The grapes swayed just above his nose.

A sparrow sitting on the wall watched quietly. "Perhaps another way around the vine would help," she suggested. The fox pretended not to hear. He did not like being observed while he failed. He searched for a taller stone, but it crumbled beneath his weight. He tried shaking the vine, but the bunches were tied high and strong. His cleverness, which usually pleased him, seemed useless that day.

After many attempts, the fox was tired and embarrassed. He looked once more at the grapes and said loudly, "They are probably sour anyway. I would not want them." Then he walked away with his tail held high. The sparrow watched him go and wondered why he had not simply admitted that the fruit was beyond his reach.

Later, the fox found blackberries growing close to the ground. They were not as grand as the grapes, but they were ripe and sweet. As he ate, he thought about the vineyard. He realized that calling the grapes sour had not made them any less desirable; it had only protected his pride for a moment. From then on, he tried to say, "I could not get it today," instead of pretending he had never wanted it. Honest disappointment, he discovered, leaves more room to learn.